

**God's Compassion and Call in
Jesus the Christ's Ministry, Incarnation, and Resurrection**

Rachel Cooley

DIV 6801 – Introduction to Christian Theology

Midterm Paper

October 31, 2019

In my understanding, Jesus' ministry and teachings, incarnation as Christ, and death and resurrection represent God's compassion for creation and human beings as well as God's continual call to live out this compassion in the here-and-now kin-dom, where love, liberation, and hope through God are abundantly ever-present even alongside suffering, oppression and marginalization, and failure to follow God's call. In this paper, I'll address some Christological statements with significant influence in the history of Christianity and continued impact on modern theological understandings I'll encounter serving as a pastor or chaplain. I'll also bring in some critiques and constructive proposals responding to traditional Christological understandings, before moving in the latter part of the paper to a more expanded exploration of my personal Christology.

We're impacted today by the focus on soteriological implications of Jesus Christ and three atonement theories developed across the centuries. In the 1090's, Anselm composed the "satisfaction theory," where human sin detracts from God's honor and Jesus in his death takes on the consequence for human sin and restores that honor.¹ Abelard debated this theory in the 1100's, arguing instead that Christ is a "moral exemplar" whose love for God and others and following of God's will make him one humans should emulate to achieve salvation. Abelard conceived of the cross as an act of "perfect love" by Christ, still glorifying his suffering and death, though refuting Anselm's argument that God needed payment.² The third theory of atonement positions Christ as victor over Satan and Satan's demons, defeating evil in the resurrection, though temporarily beset by its very real threat at the cross.³ Theologies in these three veins remain influential today, as I've heard in descriptions of "Christ dying for my sins,"

¹ Karen Baker-Fletcher et al., "Jesus Christ," in *Constructive Theology: A Contemporary Approach to Classical Themes*, ed. Serene Jones and Paul Lakeland (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2005), 170.

² Baker-Fletcher et al., "Jesus Christ," 170-71.

³ Baker-Fletcher et al., "Jesus Christ," 171.

“Christ dying for those he loved,” and “Christ defeating death and evil.” The prominent presence of these theologies indicate to me an over-emphasis on the cross, to the neglect of conversation about the teachings and incarnation of Jesus, and to a misconstruing of the nature of God’s compassion.

Professor Rieger often focuses in lectures on the lessons of Jesus’ ministry for the material world, arguing Jesus did not call for liberation in an afterlife, but justice done for the ostracized and poor *now*. In the “parable of the workers in the vineyard” (Matthew 20:1-16) and the “parable of the unforgiving servant” (Matthew 18:23-35), Rieger believes Jesus advocates for solidarity among the poor to organize against the powerful of the wealthy. Jesus focuses there and elsewhere, Rieger says in “Christ’s Offices Reconsidered,” on the “real tensions and pain of life” and leads people “to a self-critical attitude that lays open the ways in which we are all part of the system and encourages repentance and a new start.”⁴ In his ministry, Jesus both preached and practiced solidarity with the oppressed and marginalized, going again and again to the stranger and “other,” as David Jensen argues in “Christology and Triumphalism,”⁵ and calling all to follow his vision for life in God’s present kin-dom. Re-focusing on and *doing* Jesus’ teachings, especially those described here, would, in my view, bring Christians today to more faithful living of God’s call as voiced by Jesus.

The incarnation is significant to understanding God’s love and call because through it, as Cynthia L. Rigby argues in “The Scandal of Particularity,” “infinite” divine entered into “limited,” creaturely existence to show “not only that God is with us but that we as particular, limited being are included in the life and work of God.”⁶ Rigby notes how particularities of Jesus’ human identity have often been wrongly privileged over others,⁷ with Jesus’ maleness

⁴ Baker-Fletcher et al., “Jesus Christ,” 195. Rieger cites Luke 13:1-5 as an example of this.

⁵ Baker-Fletcher et al., “Jesus Christ,” 195-99.

⁶ Baker-Fletcher et al., “Jesus Christ,” 188.

used to justify patriarchy, and, in the US, Jesus' dominant portrayal as white used to justify white privilege. Kelly Delaine Brown, in her article "God Is As Christ Does: Toward a Womanist Theology," would likely respond to Cone's argument that Jesus in the 1960's US would be black, and later scholars imagining Jesus as a black *woman*, saying that womanist theology should "[describe] Christ as being embodied wherever there is a movement to sustain and liberate the entire black community, male and female," placing the "ultimate significance of Christ" in liberating activity regardless of skin color or gender.⁸ Delores Williams agrees, noting that Christology should speak to black women and relate to their "belief in Jesus/Christ/God involved in their daily affairs and supporting them" as their mother, father, sister, or brother.⁹ The incarnation is thus significant to humans, especially those who are oppressed, because it represents God's present and real compassionate work in their/our lives.

Feminists have questioned theologies idealizing Jesus' suffering and death on the cross as "perfect love," as Abelard described it, as it's often been weaponized to keep women in the role of sacrificial, abused victim. Some have proposed instead that, as Baker-Fletcher summarizes, "Jesus' willingness to die for his teachings [represents] (in Sharon Welch's words) an 'ethic of risk.'"¹⁰ Brita L. Gill-Austern, in her chapter "Love Understood as Self-Sacrifice and Self-Denial: What Does It Do to Women?," would agree with Baker-Fletcher that Christian theologies can include "life-affirming, carefully delineated interpretations of sacrifice,"¹¹ as she argues there exists a paradox in Christ's teaching that some sacrifice for others is required but that in giving, one should also receive. Jesus' ministry and life, she argues, were "simply not

⁷ Baker-Fletcher et al., "Jesus Christ," 187.

⁸ Kelly Delaine Brown, "God Is As Christ Does: Toward a Womanist Theology," *Journal of Religious Thought* 46, no. 1 (Summer-Fall 1989): 16. ATLA Religion Database.

⁹ Delores S. Williams, "Womanist-Feminist Dialogue: Differences and Commonalities," in *Sisters in the Wilderness: The Challenge of Womanist God-Talk* (Maryknoll, New York: Orbis Books, 1993), 203.

¹⁰ Baker-Fletcher et al., "Jesus Christ," 189.

¹¹ Baker-Fletcher et al., "Jesus Christ," 189.

devoid of all self-concern,” advocated for mutual relationship, and promised “abundant life and joy” by living in the kin-dom.¹² The resurrection can be seen as part of that promise, as Baker-Fletcher describes it as “an act of continuous, life-affirming, creative activity” where “redemption” and “restoration” are “available to all creation.”¹³

The degree to which I’ve seen churches talk about the cross seems inappropriate when compared to the lesser time spent talking about Jesus’s ministry and incarnation. In my personal theology and ministry, I will continually focus on Jesus’ teachings and what they call us to *do* as central, with the incarnation of secondary importance, and the cross and resurrection third. With my theological priorities ordered this way, I also allow for differing perspectives or doubts, both for myself and others, as to what exactly “Son of God” and “divine incarnate” mean and as to the “literal” occurrence of the resurrection. It is the stories and their meanings that hold significance for me, not “belief” statements or supposed uniformity of thought within a church regarding those questions. A congregation *should* cultivate more unified focus Jesus’ ministry and develop action-plans to follow his call to do justice and show hospitality to strangers.

Christ’s ministry, incarnation, and death and resurrection all demonstrate God’s endless call and compassion, which mutually reinforce each other. Jesus’ ministry challenged *and* offered empathy, opportunity for self-criticism and repentance, and new ways to live in the kin-dom.¹⁴ This is not a “pie-in-the-sky” kin-dom, but is enacted through human action to change material realities, with individuals and communities journeying to be more faithful and supported by God’s compassion—not guilt or condemnation that paralyze action—along the way. Christ’s commitment to empathetically encounter each stranger and community he met represents God’s

¹² Gill-Austern, Brita L., “Love Understood as Self-Sacrifice and Self-Denial: What Does It Do to Women?,” in *Through the Eyes of Women: Insights for Pastoral Care*, ed. Jeanne Stevenson Moessner (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 1996), 309.

¹³ Baker-Fletcher et al., “Jesus Christ,” 190.

¹⁴ Baker-Fletcher et al., “Jesus Christ,” 195.

compassion through these specific acts of ministry and through the imperative for us to likewise show compassion and create *more* love, healing, and justice. Living in the kin-dom requires facing the reality of evil and pain, though, as seen in the violence, grief, and despair present in the crucifixion story. We must not downplay the three days before the resurrection or otherwise paper over the reality of violence, evil, and related suffering inflicted on individuals and oppressed groups throughout history. The resurrection does not erase this suffering, nor is suffering required to reveal God's good. The Risen Christ instead exhibits the persistently-present existence of hope, life, and love in God's kin-dom, even alongside and in the midst of real hurt, hopelessness, and a seeming-lack of God's presence. Jesus' "ethic of risk"¹⁵ emphasizes the importance of persisting in living God's kin-dom reality despite moments where people refuse God's ever-present call and compassion. This call and compassion are present not just in the historic life of Jesus, but in the Risen Christ and continuous activity of God today. Wherever there is self-critical examination and journeying to *do* justice and compassion, "sustaining and liberating" activity like the incarnate Christ enacted,¹⁶ and mutual relationship that inspires some sacrifice but brings "abundant life and joy,"¹⁷ we live into God's compassion and call and become the "body of Christ" in the world.

Bibliography

Baker-Fletcher, Karen, Michelle A. Gonzalez, David H. Jensen, Joerg Rieger, Cynthia L. Rigby, and Deanna A. Thompson. "Jesus Christ." In *Constructive Theology: A Contemporary*

¹⁵ Baker-Fletcher et al., "Jesus Christ," 189.

¹⁶ Brown, "God Is As Christ Does," 16.

¹⁷ Gill-Austern, "Love Understood as Self-Sacrifice and Self-Denial," 309.

Approach to Classical Themes, edited by Serene Jones and Paul Lakeland, 161-199.

Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2005.

Brown, Kelly Delaine. "God Is As Christ Does: Toward a Womanist Theology." *Journal of Religious Thought* 46, no. 1 (Summer-Fall 1989): 7-16. ATLA Religion Database.

Cone, James H. "Jesus Christ in Black Theology." In *A Black Theology of Liberation*, 20th Anniversary Ed, 110-128. Maryknoll, New York: Orbis Books, 1995.

Gill-Austern, Brita L. "Love Understood as Self-Sacrifice and Self-Denial: What Does It Do to Women?" In *Through the Eyes of Women: Insights for Pastoral Care*, edited by Jeanne Stevenson Moessner, 304-21. Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 1996.

Williams, Delores S. "Womanist-Feminist Dialogue: Differences and Commonalities." In *Sisters in the Wilderness: The Challenge of Womanist God-Talk*, 178-203. Maryknoll, New York: Orbis Books, 1993.